Class 7 Social Science – Chapter 6: The Age of Reorganisation

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इस अध्याय के सभी मुख्य विषयों, पाठ में दिए गए Think About It और Let's Explore प्रश्नों तथा अंत में दिए गए सभी अभ्यास प्रश्नों के उत्तर simple English में दिए गए हैं। उत्तर कक्षा 7 के विद्यार्थियों के स्तर के अनुसार रखे गए हैं।

1. Important topics of the chapter

1. The Age of Reorganisation
2. The Shunga Dynasty and Ashvamedha Yajna
3. The Satavahana Dynasty
4. Life under the Satavahanas
5. The Chedis and King Kharavela
6. The Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas
7. Sangam Literature
8. The Cholas and King Karikala
9. Silappadikaram: The Tale of the Anklet
10. The Indo-Greeks and the Shakas
11. The Kushanas and King Kanishka
12. The Silk Route and Trade
13. Gandhara and Mathura Schools of Art
14. Cultural Exchange and Assimilation

2. The Age of Reorganisation

Important questions and answers

Q1. Why is the period after the Maurya Empire called the Age of Reorganisation?

Answer: After the decline of the Maurya Empire, many new kingdoms emerged in India. These kingdoms competed for land and power. Foreign invasions also took place. Therefore, this period is called the Age of Reorganisation.

Q2. When did the Maurya Empire come to an end?

Answer: The last Maurya emperor was assassinated around 185 BCE by his commander-in-chief, Pushyamitra Shunga.

Q3. What happened after the decline of the Maurya Empire?

Answer: The Maurya Empire broke into smaller kingdoms. Many regional rulers became powerful, and foreign invaders entered the northwestern parts of India.

Q4. How did the new kingdoms try to increase their power?

Answer: They used wars and matrimonial alliances. They also tried to control border areas to protect their kingdoms from attacks.

Q5. What were the main features of this age?

Answer: The main features were:

- The rise of many new kingdoms.
- Wars and political competition.
- Foreign invasions.
- Growth of trade and commerce.
- Development of art, architecture and literature.
- Cultural exchange between different groups.

Q6. What is a matrimonial alliance?

Answer: A matrimonial alliance is an agreement between two royal families through marriage. It was often used to build friendly relations between kingdoms.

Q7. What is a dynasty?

Answer: A dynasty is a line of rulers belonging to the same family.

3. The Shunga Dynasty

Important questions and answers

Q1. Who founded the Shunga Dynasty?

Answer: Pushyamitra Shunga founded the Shunga Dynasty.

Q2. Which regions did the Shungas rule?

Answer: They ruled over parts of northern and central India.

Q3. What was the Ashvamedha Yajna?

Answer: The Ashvamedha Yajna was an ancient Vedic ritual performed by kings to show their power and supremacy.

Q4. How was the Ashvamedha Yajna performed?

Answer: A horse was allowed to move freely with soldiers. The territories through which it passed without being stopped were considered to accept the king's supremacy. If another ruler stopped the horse, a battle could take place.

Q5. What were the contributions of the Shungas to art and literature?

Answer: The Shungas supported literature, art and architecture. Beautiful railings and carvings were added to the Bharhut Stupa. Sanskrit also became an important language for literary and philosophical works.

Q6. Who compiled the Yoga Sutras during this period?

Answer: Patanjali compiled the Yoga Sutras during this period.

Q7. What is the Bharhut Stupa famous for?

Answer: The Bharhut Stupa is famous for its carved railings and reliefs showing stories from the life of Buddha. These are important examples of early Buddhist art.

Q8. Did other schools of thought disappear under the Shungas?

Answer: No. Vedic rituals became popular again, but other schools of thought continued to flourish.

4. The Satavahana Dynasty

Important questions and answers

Q1. Who were the Satavahanas?

Answer: The Satavahanas were a powerful dynasty that ruled large parts of the Deccan from the 2nd century BCE onwards. They were also sometimes called the Andhras.

Q2. Which regions did the Satavahanas rule?

Answer: Their kingdom included large parts of present-day Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Maharashtra.

Q3. Name two important Satavahana capitals.

Answer: Amaravati and Pratishthana (Paithan) were two important capitals.

Q4. What were the main occupations and economic activities of the Satavahanas?

Answer: Agriculture, trade and commerce were important economic activities. They also carried on maritime trade with distant regions.

Q5. What do Satavahana coins tell us about their trade?

Answer: Some Satavahana coins show ships with two masts. This suggests that sea trade, shipbuilding and navigation were important.

Q6. Which goods were traded by the Satavahanas?

Answer: They traded spices, textiles, sandalwood, ivory and luxury goods. Glass and perfumed ointments were among the imported goods.

Q7. With which distant empire did the Satavahanas trade?

Answer: They had trade links with the Roman Empire.

Q8. How did trade help the Satavahana kingdom?

Answer: Trade brought wealth and taxes to the kingdom. It also supported the growth of art, literature and culture.

Q9. What was the importance of the Krishna-Godavari river system?

Answer: It supported agriculture and helped provide economic stability to the Satavahana kingdom.

Q10. What were the Naneghat caves used for?

Answer: They were located near an important trade route. They were used for collecting tolls and taxes and as resting places for traders.

5. Life under the Satavahanas

Q1. Why was Gautamiputra Satakarni named after his mother?

Answer: In the Satavahana tradition, princes were often named after their mothers. Gautamiputra Satakarni was named after his mother, Gautami Balashri.

Q2. Who was Gautami Balashri?

Answer: She was a powerful queen. She donated land to Buddhist monks and had an important inscription carved at Nashik.

Q3. What do the Naneghat inscriptions tell us?

Answer: They tell us about the Satavahana rulers, Vedic rituals, donations and the role of royal women. The inscriptions mention gifts such as land, cows, horses, elephants and silver coins.

Q4. Which script was used in these inscriptions?

Answer: The Brahmi script was used.

Q5. What do the inscriptions tell us about women?

Answer: They show that some royal women had influence and played important roles in religious activities and donations.

Q6. Which religious traditions were supported by the Satavahanas?

Answer: The Satavahanas followed Vāsudeva, another name for Krishna. They also supported Vedic scholars, Jaina monks and Buddhist monks.

Q7. What was one reason for the decline of the Satavahana Empire?

Answer: Weak central control and gradual economic decline were important reasons. In the 3rd century CE, the empire broke into smaller independent kingdoms.

Q8. What does the sculpture made by a goldsmith tell us?

Answer: It shows that people could have more than one skill. A goldsmith could also make a stone sculpture.

6. The Chedis and King Kharavela

Q1. Which dynasty ruled Kalinga after the decline of the Maurya Empire?

Answer: The Chedi Dynasty became powerful in Kalinga after the decline of the Maurya Empire.

Q2. Who was Kharavela?

Answer: Kharavela was an important ruler of the Chedi Dynasty. He followed Jain teachings and respected other schools of thought.

Q3. Why was Kharavela sometimes called a monk-king?

Answer: He was devoted to Jain teachings, so he was sometimes called bhikshu-raja, meaning monk-king.

Q4. What are the Udayagiri and Khandagiri caves famous for?

Answer: These caves near Bhubaneswar are famous for their rock-cut chambers, sculptures and carvings. They are believed to have been developed for Jain monks.

Q5. What is the Hathigumpha inscription?

Answer: It is an inscription written in the Brahmi script. It records Kharavela's military campaigns and works for the welfare of his people.

Q6. What does Kharavela's inscription tell us about religious tolerance?

Answer: It says that Kharavela respected every religious sect and repaired temples. This shows his respect for different beliefs.

Q7. What is rock-cut architecture?

Answer: Rock-cut architecture is a style in which buildings, caves or chambers are carved directly out of natural rock.

7. The Kingdoms of Southern India

Q1. Name the three important kingdoms of southern India during this period.

Answer: The three kingdoms were the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas.

Q2. Were these kingdoms part of the Maurya Empire?

Answer: No. They remained independent even when the Maurya Empire was at its height.

Q3. What did the three kingdoms contribute to southern India?

Answer: They contributed to trade, agriculture, literature, art and culture.

A. The Cholas

Q4. Who was Karikala?

Answer: Karikala was an important Chola king. According to tradition, he defeated a combined force of the Cheras and Pandyas.

Q5. What was the Kallanai or Grand Anicut?

Answer: The Kallanai was a water-diversion structure built across the Kaveri River. It helped carry water to agricultural lands in the Kaveri delta.

Q6. Why is the Kallanai important?

Answer: It improved irrigation and helped bring more land under cultivation. The Kaveri delta became known as the “rice bowl of the South”.

Q7. Is the Kallanai still useful today?

Answer: Yes. It has been restored several times and continues to support irrigation and agriculture in Tamil Nadu.

B. The Cheras

Q8. Who were the Cheras?

Answer: The Cheras, also known as the Keralaputras, ruled parts of present-day Kerala and western Tamil Nadu.

Q9. What was the capital of the Cheras?

Answer: Their capital was Vanji, identified in the textbook with present-day Karur in Tamil Nadu.

Q10. Which goods did the Cheras export?

Answer: They exported spices, timber, ivory and pearls.

Q11. With which regions did the Cheras trade?

Answer: They had important trade connections with the Roman Empire and West Asia.

C. The Pandyas

Q12. What was the capital of the Pandyas?

Answer: Madurai was the capital of the Pandyas.

Q13. What was the Pandya kingdom famous for?

Answer: It was famous for pearls, maritime power and trade with distant regions.

Q14. Which ancient writer mentioned the Pandya kingdom?

Answer: Megasthenes mentioned the Pandya kingdom in his work Indika.

Q15. What do Pandya inscriptions tell us?

Answer: They show that Pandya kings claimed to care for their people's welfare and support different schools of thought.

8. Sangam Literature

Q1. What is Sangam literature?

Answer: Sangam literature is a collection of ancient Tamil poems. It gives information about the society, culture and values of southern India.

Q2. Why is the period called the Sangam Age?

Answer: It is called the Sangam Age because assemblies of poets produced important Tamil literary works during this period.

Q3. What does the word “Sangam” mean?

Answer: It comes from the Sanskrit word sangha, meaning an association or coming together.

Q4. What subjects are discussed in Sangam poetry?

Answer: Sangam poetry discusses personal feelings such as love and social values such as bravery and generosity.

Q5. Why is Sangam literature important to historians?

Answer: It helps historians understand the life, society, culture and values of ancient southern India.

Q6. Name the three “crowned kings” associated with the Sangam tradition.

Answer: The Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas.

Model answer: Write a note on Sangam literature in about 150 words.

Sangam literature is one of the oldest forms of Tamil literature. It developed in southern India during the period of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas. The word “Sangam” means an assembly or association of poets. Sangam literature contains collections of poems that describe the life and culture of ancient Tamil society.

These poems discuss love, bravery, generosity, social values and human emotions. They also provide information about kings, cities, trade, occupations and daily life. The poems help historians understand the political, economic and cultural conditions of southern India. Sangam literature is an important part of India's literary heritage because it preserves the traditions and experiences of people who lived many centuries ago.

9. Silappadikaram: The Tale of the Anklet

Q1. What is Silappadikaram?

Answer: Silappadikaram is a famous Tamil epic. Its title means “The Tale of the Anklet”.

Q2. Who were Kannagi and Kovalan?

Answer: Kannagi was Kovalan's wife. They lived in the prosperous Chola city of Puhar.

Q3. Why did Kannagi and Kovalan travel to Madurai?

Answer: They went to Madurai to rebuild their lives after Kovalan lost his wealth.

Q4. Why was Kovalan executed?

Answer: He was falsely accused of stealing the Pandya queen's anklet and was executed by the Pandya king.

Q5. How did Kannagi prove Kovalan's innocence?

Answer: She showed her own anklet and proved that Kovalan had been wrongly accused.

Q6. What happened when the king realised his mistake?

Answer: The king was shocked by his mistake and died. The story then describes Kannagi's curse and the destruction of Madurai by fire.

Q7. What are the main messages of Silappadikaram?

Answer: The epic highlights justice, truth and the duty of a ruler to protect justice. It also provides information about cities, trade and different religious traditions.

10. The Indo-Greeks and the Shakas

The Indo-Greeks

Q1. Who were the Indo-Greeks?

Answer: The Indo-Greeks were rulers who established kingdoms in parts of northwestern India after the decline of the Maurya Empire. Some of them were descendants of Greek rulers and officials who had remained in the region.

Q2. How did the Indo-Greeks influence Indian culture?

Answer: They influenced Indian art, coins, language and administration. They also adopted some Indian religious and cultural traditions.

Q3. What does the Heliodorus pillar tell us?

Answer: The Heliodorus pillar near Vidisha shows cultural and religious connections between the Indo-Greeks and India. Its inscription praises Vasudeva.

Q4. What information do Indo-Greek coins provide?

Answer: Their coins provide information about their rulers, religious beliefs and cultural contacts. Some coins show Greek deities, while others show Indian deities such as Vasudeva-Krishna and Lakshmi.

Q5. What were the three principles mentioned in the Heliodorus pillar inscription?

Answer: Self-restraint, charity and consciousness.

The Shakas

Q6. Who were the Shakas?

Answer: The Shakas, also called Indo-Scythians, were people who entered and ruled parts of northwestern India.

Q7. When did the Shakas rule parts of the subcontinent?

Answer: According to the chapter, their kingdoms ruled from the later part of the 2nd century BCE to the 5th century CE.

Q8. What is the Shaka Samvat?

Answer: The Shaka Samvat is a calendar era that began during the Shaka period. It was adopted as India's National Calendar in 1957.

Q9. How did the Shakas contribute to Indian history?

Answer: Their rule became part of the political and cultural history of northwestern India. The Shaka Samvat calendar is also an important legacy of this period.

11. The Kushanas and King Kanishka

Q1. Who were the Kushanas?

Answer: The Kushanas originally came from Central Asia. They entered India probably in the 2nd century CE and ruled large parts of northern India.

Q2. Who was Kanishka?

Answer: Kanishka was a powerful ruler of the Kushana Dynasty. He supported art and culture and led military campaigns.

Q3. What does the inscription on Kanishka's statue say?

Answer: It calls him the “Great King, King of Kings, Son of God”.

Q4. What do Kanishka's coins show?

Answer: His coins show the emperor and different deities. Some coins show Buddha, while others show Shiva with Nandi. This reflects the presence of different religious traditions.

Q5. How did the Kushanas support trade?

Answer: They controlled important sections of the Silk Route. This helped connect India with Central Asia and other parts of Asia and the West.

Q6. What were the important contributions of Kanishka to art?

Answer: Kanishka encouraged art and culture. During the Kushana period, the Gandhara and Mathura schools of art became important.

Q7. What does the presence of different deities on Kushana coins suggest?

Answer: It suggests that different religious traditions were recognised and represented during their rule.

12. The Silk Route and Ancient Trade

Q1. What was the Silk Route?

Answer: The Silk Route was a network of trade routes connecting China with Central Asia and the Mediterranean world.

Q2. Why was the Silk Route important?

Answer: It encouraged trade between distant regions. It also helped people exchange ideas, art, beliefs and cultural practices.

Q3. How did the Kushanas benefit from the Silk Route?

Answer: Their control over important parts of the route helped trade grow between India, Central Asia and the West.

Q4. What kinds of goods were traded in ancient times?

Answer: Goods included silk, spices, textiles, ivory, pearls, timber, glass and other valuable items.

Q5. How do historians learn about ancient trade?

Answer: They study coins, inscriptions, archaeological remains, trade routes and ancient writings.

Q6. How did trade help cultural exchange?

Answer: Traders travelled between different regions and came into contact with different languages, religions and customs. These contacts helped cultures influence one another.

13. Gandhara and Mathura Schools of Art

Q1. What was the Gandhara School of Art?

Answer: The Gandhara School of Art developed in the northwestern regions of the subcontinent. It combined Indian themes with Greek and Roman artistic features.

Q2. What were the main features of Gandhara art?

Answer: Its main features included realistic human figures, detailed carvings and flowing robes. Grey-black schist stone was commonly used.

Q3. What was the Mathura School of Art?

Answer: The Mathura School of Art developed in the Mathura region of present-day Uttar Pradesh. It was known for its distinct Indian style.

Q4. What were the main features of Mathura art?

Answer: It commonly used red sandstone. Its sculptures often had fuller figures and smooth modelling, with less Greco-Roman influence than Gandhara art.

Q5. Name some figures represented in Mathura art.

Answer: Sculptures represented Indian deities and figures such as Kubera, Lakshmi, Shiva, Buddha, yakshas and yakshinis.

Q6. What is the main difference between Gandhara and Mathura art?

Gandhara School	Mathura School
Developed in the northwestern region.	Developed around Mathura in present-day Uttar Pradesh.
Combined Indian and Greek-Roman features.	Mainly reflected Indian artistic traditions.
Grey-black schist stone was commonly used.	Red sandstone was commonly used.
Buddha figures often show realistic anatomy and flowing robes.	Figures often have fuller bodies and smooth modelling.

Q7. Why are these schools of art important?

Answer: They show how different artistic traditions interacted. They also demonstrate the development of religious sculpture and Indian art.

14. Cultural Exchange and Assimilation

Q1. What is cultural assimilation?

Answer: Cultural assimilation is the process in which people or groups adopt and share elements of one another's culture.

Q2. How did foreign rulers become part of Indian society?

Answer: They interacted with local people, adopted some Indian customs and religious beliefs, and contributed to art, language, trade and administration.

Q3. Give two examples of cultural exchange during this period.

Answer: The Heliodorus pillar shows Indo-Greek religious connections. Gandhara art shows a blend of Indian and Greek-Roman artistic features.

Q4. How did different kingdoms contribute to Indian culture?

Answer: The Shungas supported art and literature, the Satavahanas encouraged trade and religious institutions, and the southern kingdoms supported Tamil literature and commerce. The Kushanas helped develop new artistic styles.

Q5. What happened to Sanskrit literature during this period?

Answer: Sanskrit literature flourished. Important Indian texts, including the Mahabharata and the Ramayana, developed over time.

Q6. What does this period teach us about Indian culture?

Answer: It teaches us that Indian culture developed through interaction, exchange and the acceptance of different traditions over time.

15. All textbook questions and answers

These are the six questions given under “Questions and Activities” on page 143 of the uploaded chapter.

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Q1. Why was the post-Maurya era also known as the era of reorganisation?

Answer: After the decline of the Maurya Empire around 185 BCE, many new kingdoms emerged. Earlier tributary kingdoms became independent. The new rulers competed for land and power. Foreign invasions also affected the northwestern region. Therefore, this period is known as the Age of Reorganisation.

Q2. Write a note on Sangam literature in 150 words.

Answer:

Sangam literature is one of the oldest forms of Tamil literature. It developed in southern India during the period of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas. The word “Sangam” means an assembly or association of poets.

Sangam literature consists of collections of poems that describe the life and culture of ancient Tamil society. These poems express personal feelings such as love and social values such as bravery and generosity. They also provide information about kings, cities, trade, occupations and daily life.

This literature is an important source for historians because it helps them understand the political, social and economic conditions of ancient southern India. It also shows the importance of poetry and literature in society. Sangam literature is a valuable part of India's cultural heritage because it preserves the traditions, ideas and experiences of people who lived many centuries ago.

Q3. Which rulers mentioned in this chapter included their mother's name in their title, and why did they do so?

Answer: Gautamiputra Satakarni was named after his mother, Gautami Balashri. The Satavahana tradition often included the mother's name at the beginning of a prince's name. This may have shown respect for the mother and recognised her importance in the royal family.

Q4. Write a note of about 250 words on one kingdom from this chapter that you find interesting. Explain why you chose it.

Answer: The Satavahana Kingdom

The Satavahana Kingdom was an important kingdom of ancient India. The Satavahanas ruled large parts of the Deccan from the 2nd century BCE. Their territory included parts of present-day Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Maharashtra. Amaravati and Pratishthana were important capitals of their kingdom.

Agriculture, trade and commerce flourished under the Satavahanas. The Krishna-Godavari river system supported farming and provided economic stability. Satavahana coins showing ships suggest that maritime trade was important. Their trade networks reached the Roman Empire.

They exported spices, textiles, sandalwood, ivory and other valuable goods. They imported items such as glass and perfumed ointments.

The Satavahanas also contributed to art, architecture and religion. They supported Vedic scholars, Jaina monks and Buddhist monks. The Karla caves and other cave structures show the artistic achievements of this period. Inscriptions provide information about their rulers, religious practices and donations.

I find the Satavahana Kingdom interesting because it developed agriculture, trade and cultural activities together. Its trade connections show that ancient India had links with distant parts of the world. Its support for different religious traditions also shows that several schools of thought could flourish during the same period.

Q5. Imagine you have the chance to create your own kingdom. What royal emblem would you choose, and why? What title would you take as the ruler? Write about your kingdom, including its values, rules and regulations, and unique features.

Answer: My Imaginary Kingdom

I would name my kingdom Peacepur. I would choose a rising sun as its royal emblem because it represents hope, knowledge and a new beginning. I would take the title “King of Peacepur”.

My kingdom would follow the values of justice, equality, peace and honesty. Every person would have the right to education, healthcare and safety. No person would be treated unfairly because of their background or beliefs.

The laws would apply equally to everyone, including the ruler. People would be encouraged to protect forests, save water and keep their surroundings clean. Farmers, teachers, doctors, artists and workers would receive respect.

My kingdom would have schools, hospitals, libraries and public gardens. Different religious and cultural traditions would be respected. People would be encouraged to settle disputes peacefully. I would work for the welfare of all citizens and make sure that no one remained hungry or uneducated.

The main aim of my kingdom would be to create a peaceful, fair and prosperous society.

Q6. Mark the approximate locations of ancient structures mentioned in the chapter on an outline map of the Indian subcontinent.

Answer: Mark these locations on an outline map. The locations are approximate.

Ancient structure	Location to mark
Bharhut Stupa	Bharhut, Madhya Pradesh

Naneghat Caves	Near Pune, Maharashtra
Karla Caves	Near Lonavala, Maharashtra
Pitalkhora Caves	Maharashtra
Udayagiri–Khandagiri Caves	Near Bhubaneswar, Odisha
Hathigumpha inscription	Udayagiri Hills, near Bhubaneswar, Odisha
Heliodorus Pillar	Near Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh
Kallanai (Grand Anicut)	Across the Kaveri River, Tamil Nadu

16. Additional important exam questions

Very short-answer questions (1 mark)

Q1. Who founded the Shunga Dynasty?

Answer: Pushyamitra Shunga.

Q2. Which ritual was performed by kings to show their supremacy?

Answer: Ashvamedha Yajna.

Q3. Name two important Satavahana capitals.

Answer: Amaravati and Pratishthana.

Q4. Who was Kharavela?

Answer: He was an important ruler of the Chedi Dynasty in Kalinga.

Q5. What was the capital of the Cholas under the tradition described in the chapter's story of Kannagi?

Answer: Puhar, also identified with Kaveripattinam, was the Chola capital in the story.

Q6. What was the capital of the Pandyas?

Answer: Madurai.

Q7. What was the capital of the Cheras according to the chapter?

Answer: Vanji, identified with present-day Karur.

Q8. Who was Karikala?

Answer: He was an important Chola king.

Q9. Who was Kanishka?

Answer: He was a powerful Kushana ruler.

Q10. Which script appears in the inscriptions discussed in the chapter?

Answer: Brahmi.

Q11. What was the Shaka Samvat adopted as in 1957?

Answer: India's National Calendar.

Q12. Name the two important schools of art discussed in the chapter.

Answer: Gandhara and Mathura.

Short-answer questions (2–3 marks)

Q1. How did trade contribute to the growth of ancient kingdoms?

Answer: Trade brought wealth and tax revenue to kingdoms. It connected distant regions and encouraged the exchange of goods, ideas and cultural practices. Trade also supported the growth of art and architecture.

Q2. What was the importance of inscriptions in ancient India?

Answer: Inscriptions provide information about rulers, their achievements, religious beliefs, donations and public works. They help historians understand the political and cultural history of the period.

Q3. How did the rulers of southern India support agriculture?

Answer: Some rulers built or supported irrigation structures. Karikala's Kallanai helped divert Kaveri water to agricultural land and supported farming in the Kaveri delta.

Q4. How did the Kushanas contribute to cultural development?

Answer: The Kushanas supported art and culture. Their period saw the development of Gandhara and Mathura art. Their control over parts of the Silk Route also encouraged trade and cultural exchange.

Q5. What is the difference between the Gandhara and Mathura schools of art?

Answer: Gandhara art combined Indian and Greek-Roman features and often used grey-black schist stone. Mathura art had a more distinct Indian style and commonly used red sandstone.

Q6. Why are coins useful sources of history?

Answer: Coins can tell us about rulers, trade, economic activity and religious beliefs. The pictures and inscriptions on coins provide evidence about the period in which they were made.

Long-answer questions (4–5 marks)

Q1. Explain the main developments of the Age of Reorganisation.

Answer: The Age of Reorganisation began after the decline of the Maurya Empire. Many new kingdoms emerged and competed for territory. The Shungas, Satavahanas and Chedis became important powers. In southern India, the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas contributed to trade and culture. Foreign rulers such as the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas also established kingdoms. Trade expanded, and art, architecture and literature developed. Cultural interaction between Indian and foreign traditions created new artistic styles.

Q2. Explain the importance of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas.

Answer: The Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas were three important kingdoms of southern India. The Cheras developed trade connections with the Roman Empire and West Asia and exported spices, timber, ivory and pearls. The Cholas supported agriculture and irrigation; Karikala's Kallanai helped bring more land under cultivation. The Pandyas were known for pearls, maritime power and trade. All three kingdoms contributed to Tamil literature, art and culture.

Q3. Explain how foreign rulers influenced Indian culture.

Answer: Foreign rulers such as the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas interacted with local people and traditions. The Indo-Greeks influenced coinage and art, while their coins sometimes depicted Indian deities. The Kushanas supported the Gandhara and Mathura schools of art. The Silk Route encouraged contact with Central Asia and other regions. These interactions helped create new forms of art, architecture and cultural expression.

Q4. Why is the Age of Reorganisation important in Indian history?

Answer: This age was important because many regional kingdoms emerged after the Maurya Empire. Trade expanded within India and with distant regions. Sanskrit and Tamil literature flourished. The period saw important developments in sculpture, cave architecture, coins and irrigation. It also shows how different cultures interacted and influenced one another.

17. Quick revision table

Topic	Remember these facts

Age of Reorganisation	New kingdoms emerged after the Maurya Empire declined.
Shungas	Founded by Pushyamitra Shunga; supported art and literature.
Satavahanas	Important Deccan dynasty; agriculture and maritime trade flourished.
Chedis	Kharavela was an important ruler of Kalinga.
Cholas	Karikala is associated with the Kallanai irrigation structure.
Cheras	Known for trade with Rome and West Asia.
Pandyas	Madurai was their capital; pearls were important in trade.
Sangam literature	Ancient Tamil poetry about society, values and emotions.
Indo-Greeks	Cultural interaction reflected in coins and the Heliodorus pillar.
Shakas	Associated with the Shaka Samvat calendar.
Kushanas	Kanishka; trade through the Silk Route.
Gandhara art	Indian themes combined with Greek-Roman features.
Mathura art	Distinct Indian style; red sandstone was commonly used.

Exam tip: First learn the names of the dynasties, their important rulers, capitals, trade activities and cultural contributions. Then practise the long-answer questions in your own words.